

# AI-Generated Models, Content and Authenticity

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## WHY THIS MODULE MATTERS

*AI-generated models and content have already caused real, public brand crises. This module examines what went wrong, and how to avoid the same mistakes with authenticity and disclosure.*

## 3.1 When the Model in the Photo Isn't Real

*Generative AI can now produce photorealistic images of human models wearing real products — in any body type, skin tone, age or setting — without a photoshoot, a model, or a studio. The commercial appeal is obvious: it is faster and cheaper than a traditional shoot, and can be framed as a route to showing products on a wider range of bodies than a brand might otherwise photograph. Two major, well-documented cases show how easily this can go wrong, for very different reasons.*

### CASE STUDY — LEVI'S AND THE “ARTIFICIAL DIVERSITY” BACKLASH

In March 2023, Levi Strauss & Co. announced a partnership with Lalaland.ai, an Amsterdam digital fashion studio, to trial AI-generated models alongside its human models. The press release framed this explicitly as a diversity initiative, stating the AI models would help create “a more inclusive, personal and sustainable shopping experience” by showing products across a wider range of body types, ages and skin tones.

The backlash was immediate and severe. Critics, including fashion industry figures and commentators, pointed out the obvious tension: Levi's was framing the use of computer-generated images of people of colour and diverse body types as a diversity win, while actual diverse models were available to hire and would not be paid for the work. Some commentators called it “artificial diversity” or “digital blackface”; a professor of fashion business management noted plainly that avoiding the costs of a real shoot — models, stylists, agencies — was a significant part of the commercial logic, whatever the stated framing.

Six days later, Levi's issued a clarifying statement: the AI models were not “a means to advance diversity” or “a substitute for the real action” the company needed to take on its diversity and inclusion commitments, and would only supplement, not replace, human model photoshoots. The reversal did not undo the reputational damage; the case is still cited today as a lesson in what happens when a genuine cost-saving decision is framed as an ethical or social good.

### CASE STUDY — VOGUE'S AI-GENERATED MODEL AD

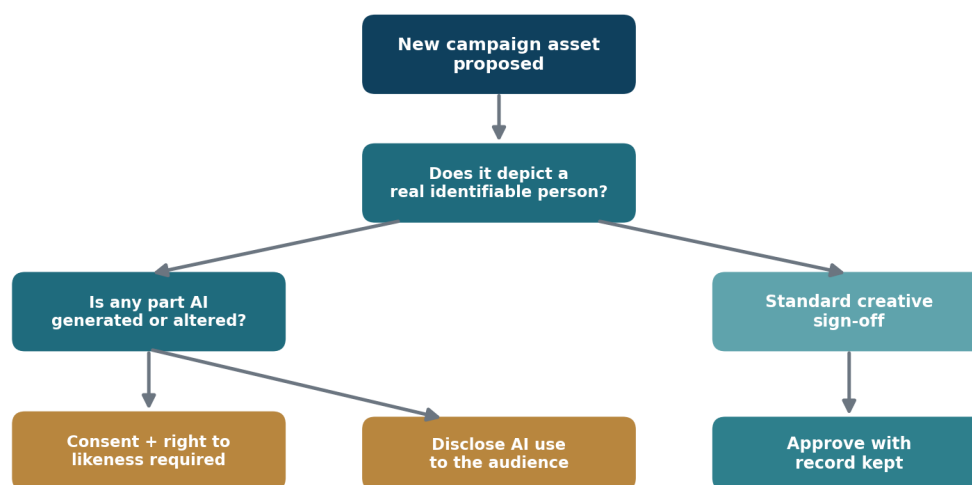
In 2025, Vogue's print edition carried a Guess advertisement featuring a model who appeared entirely conventional by the standards of fashion advertising — until it emerged the model did not exist. The image was AI-generated. Because it ran as a paid advertisement rather than an editorial spread, it met Vogue's advertising standards as they stood, but the distinction meant little to readers: to many, an AI-generated model appearing inside a magazine widely seen as the industry's arbiter of what is acceptable felt like a quiet endorsement of replacing human models altogether, whether editorial or commercial.

The reaction highlighted a problem distinct from the Levi's case: this was not about diversity messaging, but about disclosure. Readers had no way of knowing, without being told, that the person in the advertisement did not exist. Fashion models, industry commentators and technologists interviewed afterwards raised the same underlying concern — not that AI-generated imagery is inherently unacceptable, but that using it without clear disclosure erodes the basic trust a reader places in what a magazine or advertisement shows them.

## 3.2 Two Different Failures, One Shared Lesson

Levi's and the Vogue/Guess case are different failures. Levi's failure was one of framing: dressing up a cost and speed decision as a social good, which invited exactly the scrutiny that framing could not survive. The Vogue/Guess failure was one of disclosure: nothing was technically dishonest, since AI-generated advertising was permitted, but nothing told the reader what they were looking at either. Both point to the same underlying governance gap: no one had asked, before publication, how the audience would react to finding out after the fact, rather than being told upfront.

### 3.3 A Disclosure Framework for AI-Generated Content



*Every branch ends in a documented decision — never silent approval*

Figure 3.1 — A decision framework for disclosing AI-generated content in campaigns and advertising.

- **Does the image depict a real, identifiable person?** — if a real person's likeness is altered or synthetically extended, separate consent and disclosure obligations apply on top of anything below.
- **Is the image, or the person in it, wholly AI-generated?** — if so, disclose this clearly, rather than leaving it to be discovered.
- **Is the AI use being marketed as a social or ethical benefit?** — if so, that claim needs to survive the same scrutiny as any other public claim about the brand's values, not just about the technology.
- **Would the intended audience feel misled on finding out later?** — if the honest answer is yes, that is the signal to disclose now, not to hope it goes unnoticed.

**TRY THIS — YOU ARE THE BRAND MARKETING LEAD**

Scenario: your e-commerce team wants to use an AI model generator to show a new swimwear line on a wider range of body types than your usual photoshoot budget allows, and wants to describe this in a press release as part of the brand's "commitment to inclusive representation." Using the framework above, what do you require before this goes ahead? (Model answer: proceed with the AI-generated imagery only with clear, visible disclosure that the images are AI-generated — and drop or substantially rework the "inclusive representation" framing, since presenting a cost-driven technical choice as a diversity commitment is exactly what triggered the Levi's backlash. If genuine representation matters to the brand, that commitment needs to show up in who is actually hired and paid, not only in who appears synthetically on screen.)

### KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Levi's "artificial diversity" backlash shows what happens when a cost and speed decision is publicly framed as a social good — the framing became the story, not the technology itself.
- The Vogue/Guess AI-generated model ad shows that disclosure, not just permissibility, is what determines whether audiences feel misled.
- Both cases point to the same fix: ask before publication how the audience will react to finding out afterwards, and disclose accordingly.
- Genuine representation commitments should be reflected in who is hired and paid, not only in who appears synthetically in a campaign.

### FURTHER READING

- The Drum — "Why Levi's decision to use AI models misses the mark on DE&I;" (2023)
- NBC News — coverage of the Levi's/Lalaland.ai backlash and industry reaction
- TechCrunch — "The uproar over Vogue's AI-generated ad isn't just about fashion"

## MODULE 3 CHECK-IN QUIZ

Five questions to confirm your understanding before moving on. Answers are provided in the Answer Key at the end of the course.

### 1. What was the central criticism of Levi's AI-generated models announcement?

- A. That AI-generated images are always illegal
- B. That Levi's used the wrong AI vendor
- C. That the images were technically low quality
- D. That framing a cost-saving decision as a diversity initiative, instead of hiring real diverse models, rang hollow

**2. How did Levi's respond to the backlash?**

- A. It clarified that AI models were not a means to advance diversity or a substitute for real DEI action, and would only supplement human photoshoots
- B. It ignored the criticism entirely
- C. It cancelled all future photoshoots
- D. It sued its critics

**3. What was the key issue in the Vogue/Guess AI-generated model advertisement?**

- A. The advertisement was technically prohibited by Vogue's standards
- B. Readers had no way of knowing the model was AI-generated unless told
- C. The image was of poor technical quality
- D. Guess refused to comment on the image

**4. According to the disclosure framework in Module 3, what should trigger disclosure of AI-generated content?**

- A. Only when a real, identifiable person's likeness is used
- B. Disclosure is never necessary for advertising
- C. Whenever the intended audience would feel misled on finding out later
- D. Only when required by a specific named law

**5. What shared lesson do the Levi's and Vogue/Guess cases illustrate?**

- A. AI-generated imagery should never be used in fashion
- B. Only editorial content requires ethical scrutiny, not advertising
- C. Cost savings should always be the top priority in marketing decisions
- D. Ask before publication how the audience will react to finding out afterwards, and disclose accordingly